Five months later, on 8 January 1908, the *Lawoe* was involved in a third collision, once again in Colombo but this time 12 miles off the harbour. It collided with the *Muhammed Bux*, but on this occasion the Tindal of the latter vessel was in error. Though the *Muhammed Bux* suffered 'slight damage', fortunately, no lives or cargo was lost. Despite the collision the ship was able to set sail two hours later.[148]

But these collisions that the *Lawoe* was involved in were nothing compared to the troubles caused by the *Gallia*. By end-September, the police were reporting that it was laid up at Colombo with serious engine troubles and that the company had decided to discontinue its use.[149] The company had claimed that it was 'a new and an excellent steamer in all respects'. Why then did it cause such grief to its owners? Its water boilers were heavy on consuming coal, 'making it somewhat unsuitable for our service'. Except for a few trips, the *Gallia* was practically laid up in Colombo from September. To run it would be ruinous but not to sail was to make it dead capital. Besides this, some of the staff, especially its well-paid officers, had to be maintained and the insurance premium was to be remitted apart from other sundry expenses.[150]

The fallout from the *Gallia*'s repairs would be acutely felt in 1908.



Despite these problems and mishaps, the company was thriving, and evidently giving BI a run for its money. By the end of 1907, even the police, if grudgingly, conceded that the Swadeshi company was 'doing better than before'.[151] SSNCo's advertisements now clearly specified dates of passage, facilities and timetable—a vast improvement over its earlier unreliable schedule. The *Lawoe* was sailing from Tuticorin to Colombo every Monday, Wednesday and Friday 'precisely at 6 p.m.' and reaching Colombo the next day at 6 a.m. From Colombo, similarly, it was to leave 'precisely at 5:30 p.m.' every Tuesday, Thursday and Saturday, reaching Tuticorin at 6 a.m. Cargo and cattle could be booked at all railway stations with South Indian Railway and Eastern Railway. Passenger tickets could be